

Unsuccessful Painter

Maviocelli was a bitter, defeated man who lived in the piss and coal-stained gutter runway alleys of Delusione, Italy.

His face sagged in rhythmic patterns with his beard, a soggy brown beard that dripped like a wet paper bag. He was never seen detached from his emotional-support apron, covered in the dead colors of a hundred projects; the man even wore a navy-blue French beret, as if every day when putting it on in the mirror he hoped to remind himself of who he wanted to be.

He owned a hovel in this beaten mess, more than could be said for those who lived in boxes and dumpsters, and from his hovel he painted his art out on canvases he could barely afford, and sold them right off easels that could barely hold them. His colors were low-quality, dreary and smeary, so he had to use each one intelligently. He wanted to paint of hope, but the colors he had only matched his own destitute situation. He could only paint of what he knew. It plagued his mind like cloying sickness.

The alley his store was on was an ignored one. Only the impoverished trotted its unfortunate cobbled steps, and only the blessed would ever think of purchasing art. This cruel dichotomy left Maviocelli penniless. On the rare occasion a rich Dumpster Diver, who searched the slums in the hopes of finding a hidden gem exactly like Maviocelli's shop in hopes of buying and reselling the small piece, they would walk past his work and eye each one with the look one might give a fermented jar that had been preserved as long ago as houses didn't have windows.

“It’s dreary, dearie, who would ever want something as dreadful as this? Art truly reflects its creators!” they’d laugh, and Maviocelli felt his insides dip a little deeper into the boiling ocean of melted wax he called a heart.

He’d crack a smile, he’d crack inside.

No man, no woman, no living thing on this Earth, should be subject to as much rejection as I have, Maviocelli would think to himself late at night, unable to even afford the drinks that he would wish to drown his sorrows in.

Whenever he had this conversation with himself, he used to stream tears from his eyes. One day, that had stopped, and he never knew why.

It is only natural then that I am doomed. To have a voice whose purpose is to be talked over is worse than never having a voice at all.

As a kid, back when he still lived in the countryside, back when his nonna had still been alive, back when the outside world was composed of rolling fields of golden wheat instead of stone-cold machinations of misery, a blank sheet of off-white papyrus had been the favorite gift of sweet young Maviocelli.

When he had drawn, it resembled a portal to another world. When he had shown it to those around him, they had clapped and cheered, their delight as clear on their face as the sun’s warm splash on acres and acres of land. One could imagine each particle of dirt becoming warm enough to hug.

Maviocelli grabbed one of his pieces that had been sitting on display waiting for some passerby who would never come to congratulate it, and forced a hole through it with his discolored and seam-stripped shoe.

Then, from the glossary of a book about artistic technique, Maviocelli ripped a page from its binding. He set its blank side facing up on the only table he owned, and grabbed a brush. If he wasn't able to cry, he would remember how. *I must retain the ability to be dehumanized*, he reasoned to himself, *because at least then I remain human*.

He drew a picture of himself in a house on a hill, where the sun was large enough to engulf the land and the sky and all between.

Author's Note: *I think it's interesting in this little story I wrote that Maviocelli never actually gets to find out if he's talented or not. It's not clear if he's a hidden genius overlooked due to circumstances, or if he is as bad as the world makes him believe. Does it matter? Who knows, obviously the point of art is not to be the best at it. But I think it's still an interesting thing the character never gets to find out. Do I know as the author? No, I don't. I prefer it ambiguous.*

Maviocelli has a lot of myself in him even from just this short description—at least a lot of myself from some of my lowest points. That desire to be creative but feeling fraudulent in it. That desire to break out of a life of monotony to prove that vividness of the visions in your head. And yet despite his efforts and hopes, he is turned away and never given a true chance through circumstances not directly of his own cause. I think that's inherently very sympathetic, or at least I would think so. But say what you will, he doesn't give up. He's turned

suffering into its own art; and whether that's mentally healthy or not is up for debate, but at the least, it's very poetically appealing.

The fact that he's physically very destitute and poor, obviously, also pleads for sympathy. It's basically one long tug at the heart strings with the description of this guy, nothing seems to go right for him. He's much like a pauper, a comedic old-timey sad clown whose misery exists to be mocked. I've always loved that archetype, because there is something sadly hilarious, or hilariously sad, about overwhelming and senseless tragedy. You want to laugh, but you want to offer a hug as well. It's a warm space between hurt and schadenfreude. I've always been weirdly fascinated with it.

Paranoid Person

Violet wasn't a paranoid person, she had just had experiences leaving reality before. It's not something you're ever prepared for, and once you'd done it once or twice you were pretty on-edge for when it might happen again.

It was something that happened when you weren't paying attention, when you were forgetting, when you were sitting atop your bed in satin silk pajamas and your hair not fully dried post-shower, drifting aloft between no space.

It didn't care whether you had gotten both slippers on or not, and it didn't care if you had kept your glasses on or remembered your retainer that night.

So if she forgot to remember when passing out on her bed late that night after another day of posting obsessively to her blog where no one believed her, she had a good reason to be pretty afraid of where she might end up next.

It wasn't scary to leave this world, now that she was familiar with what it felt like. The fear mostly resided in the fear of never being able to come back. She had a duty, she felt, to prove something. That's why in the notebook beside her bed, she recorded her thoughts and experiences. She would translate them to audio logs and lengthy posts on her website later.

She kept a camera by her bed, too, in case she was lucky enough to get a photograph of what was happening when things switched the wrong way. A pointless effort, she was sure, because she was sure that it was a local phenomenon; not something she could capture in picture.

Reactions on her website came in one of two forms: "Wow, this is such a cool blend of fiction and reality! I love the way you tell stories!" and "You're batshit fucking crazy, woman!"

She was used to it. It was more unreasonable to ask people to believe the kinds of things she was describing, she knew. And yet despite its hopelessness, its fruitless nature, she felt it was her duty to be honest. If she left and had left nothing behind, then she wasn't even gone; she simply never was.

Violet knew she wasn't crazy. She's known since she was a kid. She's gotten these... *impulses*, that told her certain things. They told her what was really happening. The real

reason people were doing things. She could never explain how she knew, she just *knew*. And she was just about always right—so how could she be crazy?

She knew it wasn't an argument that would hold up in court, or even hold up on the forum boards on her website, but there was a certain kind of self-trust you developed when everything people gave you was wrong and everything you made for yourself worked.

Sitting there on her warm and pine-scented bed, Violet recalled a time before she first felt like she was leaving reality; a time before focusing her proprioception manually just to stay in place didn't feel necessary. Life could've been simpler. There could've been much less to think about, if she took the answers she was given.

If for just one moment, she could go back to that... relive that a little longer... what would that be like? Was it ok? Could she allow herself this one rest?

Violet began to shift and leave. As she fell asleep, her bed was empty; and no one paid her rent later that month.

Author's Note: I, as the author, happen to know that Violet's paranoia is justified and the supernatural things she's describing are real. Sorry if that kills the wonder because this short story works way better with the answer undetermined. Is anything she believes real? Is her leaving this reality a metaphor? It's a way better short story that way, but unfortunately, I know she's telling the truth because she's a pre-existing character from an old book draft. Violet leaves reality by being too detached from the lie it perpetuates, and now has to help the world find truth by navigating a pseudo-space called Abstraction.

I think everyone has been in that position of knowing something to be the case, but no one will believe you. Maybe it happens more to others, maybe to some it's just a disagreement on the playground and to others it's far more serious accusations that no one will take seriously; but I think everyone has experienced something like that. Another intrinsically sympathetic situation, even if you as the reader aren't believing everything she's saying—you sympathize with her conviction in it and that feeling of injustice and alienation.